women. While the historical data is patchy and ambiguous, we do have a host of suggestive details.

Khajuraho's culture was evidently sex-positive, certainly among its elites and aristocrats, who were part of a class of Indians that had actively cultivated the art of sex and the sexual escapade since at least Vatsayayana, author of the *Kamasutra*, the most famous of the many treatises on kama, or *ars erotica*, in ancient India. Largely a secular work written centuries before Khajuravahaka, at the start of the Gupta Empire, the *Kamasutra* remained a popular and influential text for a millennium, especially with the urban upper crust. It defends the pursuit of erotic pleasure as a goal in itself, apart from the reproductive purpose of sex. Part Epicurean, write scholars Wendy Doniger and Sudhir Kakar in the introduction to their translation, the *Kamasutra* is about 'the art of living—about finding a partner, maintaining power in a marriage, committing adultery, living as or with a courtesan, using drugs—and also about the positions in sexual intercourse'.[25] It posits 'that pleasure needs to be cultivated, that in the realm of sex, nature requires culture'. It emphasizes grooming, etiquette, diplomacy and even post-coital conversation.

The *Kamasutra* does have a distinctly patriarchal script and many of its suggestions strike modern readers as cringe-inducing, manipulative and retrograde. But it also defends choice, agency and self-cultivation for at least a certain class of women—and a woman as a 'full participant in sexual life, very much a subject in the erotic realm, not a passive recipient of the man's lust'. Not just a manual for men, it also offers advice to maidens, courtesans, wives and mistresses, and sees women as individuals in an exciting social game. 'It is surprisingly sympathetic to women,' write Doniger and Kakar, 'particularly to what they suffer from inadequate husbands.' It is attentive to a woman's 'feelings and emotions that a man needs to understand for the full enjoyment of erotic pleasure', and argues 'that a woman who actively enjoys sex will make it much more enjoyable for him'. Though it's now all but ignored in India, and not seen as an ancient Sanskrit text worth celebrating, write Doniger and Kakar, 'there is nothing remotely like it even today, and for its time, it was astonishingly sophisticated'. Vatsyayana even advances 'the radical notion that the